Praise of the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places

Aṣṭamahāsthānacaityastotra · Toh 1134 · Derge Tengyur
གཏས་ཆེ་པ་བོར་བྱ་ཀ་རྒྱ་ཆོད་རྟེ་ལ་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise of the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places, in Sanskrit the Aṣṭamahāsthānacaityastotra and in Tibetan Né Chenpo Gyé kyi Chöten la Töpa, is a short devotional hymn in verse that its colophon attributes to the great master Nāgārjuna. The eight great places are the sites of the chief events of the Buddha's life, long honored by pilgrims in India, and each stanza of the hymn recalls one or more of those events, among them his birth in Kapilavastu, his victory over Māra at the seat of awakening, the taming of maddened elephants, the turning of the wheel of the Dharma and the display of miracles, and his final passing into nirvāṇa. Every stanza closes with homage to the stūpa that marks the place where these things happened. It is Toh 1134 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra), the hymns composed by Indian masters in honor of the Buddha and other objects of devotion.

In the language of India: Aṣṭamahāsthānacaityastotra
In the language of Tibet: Praise of the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places

Homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī.

First he brought forth the mind set on supreme awakening,
And for three countless eons he gathered the accumulations;
At the seat of awakening the Buddha subdued Māra:
I pay homage to the stūpa of the great awakening.

In Kapilavastu, the city that became the ground of the Dharma,
He was born of his mother Māyā into Śuddhodana's Śākya clan;
Rising forth at the right side, he was received by Brahmā:
I pay homage to the stūpa where auspiciousness arose.

He went for alms to Vārāṇasī and other places,
And when, by the power of the fingers of his hand,
He had tamed Bimbisāra's maddened elephants,
He tamed the city as well: to that stūpa I pay homage.

While he was resting in the meadows,
Halumañju offered him honey, and then,
Dying in a well, was born in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three:
I pay homage to the stūpa where compassion arose.

When Brahmā had offered him a wheel, he turned the Wheel;
By his power he subdued the six non-Buddhist (tīrthika) teachers;
With hosts of emanations he delighted gods and humans:
I pay homage to the stūpa where he displayed miracles.

As Nanda and the other hosts of nāgas paid him homage and service,
A maiden served him milk;
With his word he subdued the entire world without exception:
I pay homage to the stūpa of the peaceful Victor (the Buddha).

Encircled by bodhisattvas and pratyekabuddhas
And by the assembly of śrāvaka arhats,
He set them firmly in vows and moral discipline:
I pay homage to the stūpa of complete purity.

With the intent of taming beings through impermanence,
After descending from the gods, at the close of all his deeds,
When Cunda had made his plea, after three months he reached the end:
I pay homage to the stūpa where he passed into nirvāṇa.

The Praise of the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places, composed by the great master Nāgārjuna, is complete.

Translator's Notes

• In the second stanza the word rendered "side" (sta zur) is uncommon; the line is taken as the infant coming forth at his mother's right side and being received by Brahmā. Halumañju is kept as the Tibetan transliterates it; the episode is the familiar one of the monkey who offered honey to the Buddha and then died in a well and was reborn among the gods of the Thirty-Three, but the name itself could not be further identified. In the sixth stanza the phrase rendered "with his word" (bka' dang) is terse and its construction uncertain, and the relation between the nāgas' homage and the maiden's offering of milk is compressed in the Tibetan.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.